company" among the final bidders "with enough money, clout and experience"' in the automotive industry to 'successfully manage the brands'.

By December 2007, reports surfaced that Ford would announce its decision early the following year. There was strong speculation that the preferred choice would be Tata Motors. Newspaper reports suggested that the company's offer was 'said to be in the range of $1.8 bn–$2.2 bn (£908 m–£1.1 bn)'.

The next month, Lewis Booth, executive vice president of Ford Europe and Premier Automotive Group (PAG), issued a statement saying: 'Ford is committed to focused negotiations at a more detailed level with Tata Motors concerning the potential sale of the combined Jaguar Land Rover business.'

In the meantime, Ratan continued with his efforts to counter the negative reports appearing in the British newspapers. According to the *Financial Times*, he said, 'We would leave the management more on its own to be more responsible for budgets and oversight than micromanaging the day-to-day business of the company.'

In the same article, Ratan was also quoted as emphasizing the synergy that could be developed when the two companies cooperated, 'Where we can really add value is in co-operating on engineering and development, which are considerably cheaper than in the West … I think we understand Asia better, so we can add value there.'

Courage of Conviction

For Ratan and the Tata Group, 25 March 2008 was a red-letter day. On that day, Tata Motors signed the agreement with Ford Motor Company to buy its luxury brands, Jaguar and Land Rover. It signalled the change that three months earlier *The Economist* had predicted would come about, that the 'future of these two grand old badges will be shaped not in Coventry, cradle of the British motor industry, but in Pune, home of Tata Motors'. The signing took place in Birmingham with Kant, Gandhi and Ramakrishnan representing Tata Motors. Ratan had hurt his back and could not attend in person, although he was connected through a video link. It was an all-cash deal, for about $2.3 billion (£1.15 billion). 'People may say anything' but it was a 'steal', says Kant.